

Petra

Hidden from the outside world for hundreds of years, the Nabataean caravan city of Petra lay at an important crossroads on trading routes between Arabia, Egypt and Syria–Phoenicia. At the height of their power, the Nabataeans were a wealthy and powerful people controlling vast expanses of desert located in present-day Jordan. Tucked away between desert canyons and mountains, the capital of their empire was half-built, half-carved from rose-coloured sandstone between 400 BCE and 106 CE.

An ingenious water management system allowed Petra to thrive in an otherwise arid area: dwellings were simple, while civic and religious architecture was a blend of Assyrian, Egyptian, Greek and Roman influences. Façades blend simplicity and opulence with columns and carvings: the huge Khazreh or Treasury, tomb of King Aretas III (r.85–62 BCE), incorporates Corinthian and Nabataean columns (opposite), as well as friezes carved from solid rock, and figures from both Nabataean and Greek mythology.

